

Seawall height in Boca Raton

The elevation your city requires, the datum it is measured in, and the section of code that says so.

BOCA RATON • PALM BEACH COUNTY

4.0 – 6.0 ft NAVD88

Boca Raton sets a band, not a single number. The city's Engineering Design Standards Manual requires any new or replaced seawall or dock to reach 4.0 ft NAVD88 and not exceed 6.0 ft NAVD88. The Code of Ordinances also carries its own bulkhead minimum, plus 5.00 feet with no datum stated (Sec. 22-31(5)), so ask the city in writing which figure and datum it will apply to your permit.

The detail

MINIMUM	4.0 ft NAVD88, for any new or replaced seawall or dock, publicly or privately owned.
MAXIMUM	6.0 ft NAVD88.
BUILD FOR MORE	Standard 3 requires the wall to be designed and constructed so a further 12 to 18 inches can be added later and the wall stays structurally sound without altering it.
MATCH THE NEIGHBOURS	The wall must be designed and built to harmonize with the adjacent grades and seawalls. EDSM 7.7, Standard 2.
TWO FIGURES, TWO DOCUMENTS	The manual states 4.0 to 6.0 ft NAVD88. Code Sec. 22-31(5) separately says no bulkhead may be built lower than plus 5.00 feet and names no datum. Get the city's answer on which governs, in writing.
NOT PAST THE PROPERTY LINE	Seawalls and bulkheads may not be built beyond the property line; the wet face sits on the property line under Code Sec. 26-146. EDSM 7.7.1(4).
WHERE IT IS WRITTEN	Engineering Design Standards Manual section 7.7, Minimum Criteria for Waterway Features, updated January 2025; Code of Ordinances Ch. 22, Art. II, Sec. 22-31.
INSPECTIONS	A zoning location survey must be approved before the cap goes on, and a final engineer report with the cap elevation and photographs is required after construction.

Where this comes from: City of Boca Raton Engineering Design Standards Manual § 7.7 and 7.7.1, Minimum Criteria for Waterway Features (updated January 2025); Code of Ordinances Ch. 22, Marine Structures, Sec. 22-31 (Supp. 72 Upd. 1)

Verified: 2026-09. Rules change — check the date above against today.

Before you call a contractor

1 Know your datum

A height means nothing without the datum it is measured from. NAVD88 and MLW are different reference points and the same wall gives different numbers in each. Ask which one any quoted elevation refers to.

2 Get the existing elevation surveyed

You cannot tell whether a wall meets the requirement by looking at it. A surveyor shooting the top of the cap settles it in an hour.

3 Ask what triggers the requirement

Most cities only apply the minimum to new walls or to substantial repair. What counts as substantial is defined differently in each city, and it is usually a percentage of length or of cost.

4 Ask about building higher now

Several cities require a wall built below the final figure to be engineered so it can be raised later. Doing it once is cheaper than doing it twice.